

Trump Doctrine 2.0: An Analysis of 2025 Economic Policy, Market Volatility, and Key Actor Interactions

Section 1: Summary

The first ten months following the inauguration of the second Trump administration in 2025 were defined by a radical and aggressive "America First" trade policy that triggered unprecedented stock market volatility. This report provides an in-depth analysis of the impact of major events and economic policies during this period on the stock market from the perspective of four key actors: Politics, Institutions, the Fed, and the Public.

The administration's core policy stance was the imposition of sweeping tariffs using the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA). In February, tariffs were imposed on China, Canada, and Mexico under the pretext of combating fentanyl trafficking and illegal immigration. On April 2, dubbed "Liberation Day," the trade deficit was declared a national emergency, leading to the announcement of a universal minimum tariff and country-specific reciprocal tariffs on nearly all imports.

These policies precipitated the momentous stock market crash of April 2025. This event demonstrated a powerful feedback loop where the administration's unilateral policy decisions triggered a panic response from institutional investors and the general public, which in turn forced a partial policy reversal (a 90-day tariff pause). Buoyed by the policy suspension, the passage of a tax cut bill, and expectations of a Fed rate cut, the market executed a V-shaped recovery, approaching all-time highs by the end of the year.

However, a severe imbalance lurked beneath this financial market recovery. While the S&P 500 recovered, the economic reality for the general public deteriorated due to tariff-induced price hikes and a slowing labor market. The consumer confidence index remained at historic lows, revealing a dangerous decoupling between market performance and the public's economic well-being.

In conclusion, 2025 was a year in which a "new equilibrium" was formed, characterized by a

repeating cycle of administration policy shocks, extreme market reactions, and subsequent policy adjustments. The weaponization of IEEPA, the rise of American-style industrial policy, and the decoupling of the market and public sentiment are structural changes that will serve as key factors amplifying uncertainty for the U.S. economy and financial markets beyond 2026.

Section 2: The Economic Landscape at the Start of the Second Term

2.1 The Inherited Economy (January 2025)

When the second Trump administration took office in January 2025, the U.S. economy was in a solid state. The economic growth rate was on an upward trend, the unemployment rate remained low, and inflation was slowing.¹ This stable macroeconomic environment provides crucial context. It suggests that the administration's subsequent radical policies were not a response to an economic crisis but rather preemptive measures based on an ideological goal to fundamentally reshape the existing economic order. The stable economy, paradoxically, provided the political space for the administration to pursue unconventional policies free from existing constraints, which in turn created a level of policy risk that the market had not anticipated.

2.2 The Proclaimed Agenda: "America First" and Project 2025

The administration's economic policy was based on a clear economic nationalism. The core of its platform was steep protective tariffs, tax cuts, and extensive deregulation.¹ In the inaugural address on January 20, 2025, the president pledged to "immediately begin the overhaul of our trade system to protect American workers and families," signaling a strong push for these policies.²

This policy direction was deeply linked to the blueprint of "Project 2025," led by the conservative Heritage Foundation. Project 2025 is a vast, 900-page plan to strengthen presidential executive power and swiftly implement conservative policies.³ The economic core

of this plan included corporate tax cuts, the dismantling of worker protections, and a reduction in federal investment ⁵, and notably, it even included measures to weaken the independence of the Federal Reserve and strengthen the administration's control over monetary policy.³ The appointment of hardline protectionists like Peter Navarro within the administration was a clear signal of this policy intent.²

2.3 Initial Market and Institutional Mood

Wall Street and many Big Tech companies generally held a positive view of the second Trump administration, with expectations of deregulation and tax cuts.⁶ The market's initial reaction immediately after the inauguration reflected this, with the S&P 500 index showing gains.⁷

However, a deep sense of anxiety existed beneath this superficial optimism. Pre-inauguration market analysis had already warned of increased volatility, and uncertainty about the direction of trade policy was pressuring the market, as seen in the underperformance of the small-cap Russell 2000 index and a decline in the Nasdaq.⁸ This shows that market participants were navigating between two conflicting aspects of the administration's policies: the pro-growth factors of tax cuts and deregulation, and the anti-growth factor of protectionism. The initial market rise suggests that investors underestimated the destructive power of the latter and placed greater weight on the benefits of the former. This fragile market optimism stood on a foundation that could easily crumble under a strong policy shock, serving as a precursor to the extreme market crash in April.

Table 1: Timeline of Major Economic Policies and Market Events in 2025 (January-October)

Date	Political/Policy Event	Institutional/Market Reaction	Fed/Public Reaction
Jan 20	Trump is inaugurated. Declares "America First" trade policy.	Initial market reaction is positive, with the S&P 500 rising.	University of Michigan Consumer Sentiment Index remains robust at 71.7.
Feb 1	IEEPA invoked. Tariffs announced	Canada/Mexico secure a 30-day	Regional Feds begin analyzing the

	on China (10%), Canada/Mexico (25%) under pretext of fentanyl/illegal immigration.	delay through negotiations. China immediately announces retaliatory tariffs and files a WTO complaint.	inflationary impact of tariffs. Consumer sentiment begins to decline.
Mar 4	Tariffs on Canada and Mexico take effect.	Corporate concerns over supply chain risks increase.	-
Apr 2	"Liberation Day" declared. A 10% baseline tariff on all imports and country-specific reciprocal tariffs (e.g., EU 20%, China additional 34%) are announced.	Stock market crash begins. S&P 500 plummets 10% in two days, wiping out \$6.6 trillion in market cap. M&A market freezes.	Consumer confidence index plunges to post-pandemic lows. Investor sentiment enters a state of extreme fear.
Apr 7	S&P 500 hits its lowest point of the year, down nearly 20% in seven weeks.	VIX index spikes. Wall Street calls for a policy pause.	-
Apr 9	Administration succumbs to market pressure, announces a 90-day pause on new tariffs for countries other than China.	Market begins a V-shaped rebound. Major indices record their largest single-day gains in years.	-
Jul-Aug	Tax cut bill passes Congress. Tentative	S&P 500 surges more than 35%	-

	agreements to lower tariffs reached with the EU, Japan, etc. Adjusted reciprocal tariffs take effect on August 7.	from its April low. Corporate earnings are strong.	
Aug 29	De Minimis (\$800 duty-free) provision is eliminated.	E-commerce and retail companies face increased cost burdens.	-
Sep	The Fed cuts the benchmark interest rate by 0.25% due to concerns about an economic slowdown.	The market anticipates further rate cuts.	-
Oct	Administration expands government intervention (golden shares, etc.) in strategic industries like rare earths.	S&P 500 approaches all-time highs, but public economic pessimism deepens.	74% of the public responds that economic conditions are poor. The gap between the market and public sentiment widens.

Section 3: The First Salvo (January – March 2025)

3.1 Political Action: The Invocation of IEEPA

On February 1, 2025, the Trump administration declared a national emergency over the "influx

of illegal aliens and illicit drugs, including fentanyl".⁹ This served as the legal justification for invoking the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA). Based on this act, the administration signed an executive order imposing a 25% tariff on most goods from Canada and Mexico and a 10% tariff on all goods from China, effective February 4.² This was an unprecedented use of emergency powers to implement broad trade policy, completely bypassing the traditional framework of trade negotiations. This action shifted trade issues from the realm of economic debate to that of national security and sovereignty. By linking tariffs to politically sensitive and difficult-to-resolve issues like fentanyl and immigration, it dramatically raised the threshold for negotiation and maximized unilateral U.S. pressure. This move signaled to institutional investors a new reality where global supply chain risks could now shift abruptly based on unpredictable security declarations.

3.2 Institutional and International Reaction

The reaction to this measure was immediate and multifaceted. Within the U.S., it revealed a political divide, with support from Republican lawmakers and strong criticism from Democrats.¹⁴

The international response varied distinctly by country. Canada and Mexico, deeply integrated with the U.S. economy, immediately entered negotiations and succeeded in obtaining a 30-day delay on the tariffs in exchange for promises to enhance border security and cooperate on drug trafficking enforcement.¹² At the same time, both countries prepared lists of retaliatory tariffs on billions of dollars of U.S. goods, keeping the option of a counter-attack open.¹⁶ In contrast, China chose direct confrontation over negotiation. When the 10% tariff went into effect as scheduled on February 4¹², China immediately announced retaliatory tariffs on U.S. goods and filed a complaint against the U.S. at the World Trade Organization (WTO). The U.S. Chamber of Commerce even described China's WTO complaint as "justified," indicating that the administration's action was widely seen as a move that undermined international trade norms.¹³ These differing national responses foreshadowed that the administration's trade strategy would unfold in a dual manner: pressuring allies into submission while escalating conflict with competitors. This presented companies with the complex task of not just "de-risking from China" but also re-evaluating the political risks associated with every trading partner individually.

3.3 The Federal Reserve's Stance

The Federal Reserve did not issue an immediate official statement on the tariff measures, but its regional banks quickly began analyzing the potential economic shock. The Boston Fed estimated that the tariffs could raise core inflation by up to 0.8 percentage points²⁰, and the Atlanta Fed also analyzed that it would lead to price increases for everyday consumer goods.²¹ Notably, a survey by the Richmond Fed reported a sharp increase in the proportion of Chief Financial Officers (CFOs) who cited "trade and tariffs" as their most pressing business concern.²² This shows that the Fed began to seriously recognize and model the risk of stagflation (inflation during an economic recession) caused by the tariff policy from an early stage. The Fed was now forced to consider the administration's unpredictable political variables as a major factor in its monetary policy decisions.

3.4 Public Sentiment

Robust consumer sentiment began to cool rapidly with the announcement of the administration's tariff policy. The University of Michigan's Consumer Sentiment Index fell from 71.7 in January to 64.7 in February²³, a result of a sharp increase in one-year inflation expectations.²⁴ Consumers began to feel anxious that the tariffs would ultimately be passed on to them as direct price increases in their daily lives. This is a significant indicator that the policy announcement had an immediate impact not only on financial markets but also on the economic outlook of the general public.

Section 4: The 'Liberation Day' Shock: A Multifaceted Analysis (April – May 2025)

4.1 The Political Catalyst: 'Reciprocal Tariffs'

On April 2, 2025, President Trump designated the day "Liberation Day" and declared the U.S. trade deficit itself a national emergency.² The new tariff system announced on this basis delivered a shock of a different magnitude to the market. The measure consisted of two stages. First, a universal baseline tariff of 10% was to be imposed on almost all imported goods starting April 5. Second, additional "reciprocal tariffs" ranging from 11% to 50% were to be imposed on major trading partners starting April 9.² A 20% tariff was announced for the

European Union (EU), 24% for Japan, and an additional 34% for China, which was already subject to tariffs.²⁶ Unlike previous measures that targeted specific items or countries, this was a full-scale action aimed at the global trading system itself. It sent a powerful and shocking signal to market participants that the U.S. administration could unilaterally reshape the world economic order based on political ideology rather than economic rationality. This was the decisive moment that forced the market to move beyond simply calculating tariff costs to fundamentally reassessing the risk of the U.S. presidency itself.

4.2 Institutional Collapse

The "Liberation Day" announcement triggered immediate panic in the financial markets. In the two days following the announcement, the Dow Jones Industrial Average plummeted by more than 4,000 points (9.5%), the S&P 500 fell by 10%, and the Nasdaq Composite dropped by 11%. The market capitalization lost amounted to \$6.6 trillion, the worst two-day loss in history.²⁵ The S&P 500 eventually fell nearly 20% over seven weeks, hitting its lowest point of the year on April 7.²⁹ The VIX, known as the "fear index," soared to its highest level since the 2020 pandemic.²⁵

The shock was even more concentrated in certain sectors. Big Tech companies, heavily reliant on global supply chains, suffered massive losses. Apple's stock price plunged, and Amazon's volatility became extreme.⁶ The mergers and acquisitions (M&A) market completely froze, with negotiators describing it as "pens down" as bidders withdrew from negotiation tables.⁶ Some large corporations had anticipated this crisis and used a strategy of stockpiling inventory in advance. Amazon used its vast financial resources to build up inventory before the tariffs took effect ⁶, a paradoxical phenomenon showing that the administration's unpredictable policies could actually provide a competitive advantage to dominant large corporations.

Table 2: Summary of 'Liberation Day' Reciprocal Tariffs (As announced on April 2, 2025)

Country/Region	Baseline Tariff	Additional Reciprocal Tariff	Total Effective Rate (Approx.)
All Countries	10%	-	10%+
China	10%	34%	44% (Over 54% with existing tariffs)

European Union (EU)	10%	20%	30%
Vietnam	10%	46%	56%
Cambodia	10%	49%	59%
Japan	10%	24%	34%
Taiwan	10%	32%	42%
South Korea	10%	25%	35%
India	10%	26%	36%
Note: The total effective rate is a simple sum of the baseline and additional tariffs and may not include other pre-existing tariffs. 26			

4.3 The Fed's Dilemma

The Fed faced a classic stagflation shock. Tariffs were inherently an inflationary factor, but the market crash and the resulting extreme economic uncertainty were factors that hindered growth and applied deflationary pressure. With two opposing risks occurring simultaneously, the Fed could not move rashly. However, the market had already begun to anticipate and price in the Fed's intervention. Market participants quickly formed expectations that the Fed would implement one or two 0.25% rate cuts by the end of 2025 to offset the economic damage.²⁹ This shows that the market judged that the Fed would ultimately be responsible for cleaning up the economic aftermath of the political risks created by the administration.

4.4 Public Reaction

The panic in the financial markets immediately spread to the sentiment of the general public. The Conference Board's Consumer Confidence Index plunged to 86.0, its lowest level since the pandemic, and the "Expectations Index," which indicates future expectations, fell to a 13-year low.³⁰ Consumers expressed widespread pessimism about the future.³⁰ The University of Michigan's Consumer Sentiment Index also plummeted from 64.7 in February to 52.2 in April.²³ This was because consumers felt the fear of direct price increases as the tariff policy was widely reported in the media.³² Investor sentiment, as measured by the American Association of Individual Investors (AAII), turned extremely bearish³³, and public protests against the administration's policies also spread.³⁴

4.5 The Decisive Interaction and Policy Reversal

The unprecedented scale of the market crash and the collapse of consumer sentiment exerted immense political pressure on the administration. Prominent institutional investors like Bill Ackman likened the tariff measures to "economic nuclear war" and publicly called for a 90-day policy pause.²⁸

This pressure formed a powerful feedback loop. Faced with the crisis of a financial system collapse, the administration was the first to back down. On April 9, President Trump announced a 90-day pause on the new country-specific tariffs for countries other than China.²

The market's reaction was immediate and explosive. The news of the policy pause triggered a massive relief rally, and major indices recorded their largest single-day gains in years.²⁵ From this point, the market entered a strong rebound phase, with the S&P 500 soaring more than 35% from its April 7 low.²⁹ This series of events imprinted on the market a new dynamic: that the administration's unilateral policies could be controlled through the market's extreme reaction. However, this was a dangerous equilibrium that only worked in the extreme situation of a near-system collapse.

4.6 Public Ridicule: The Emergence of the 'TACO' Phenomenon

The dramatic policy reversal in April brought relief to the market, but it also created a new public perception of the administration's decision-making process. As the pattern of making strong threats and then retreating under market pressure repeated, a new term was born to mock it.

On May 2, 2025, Financial Times columnist Robert Armstrong dubbed this phenomenon "the TACO theory".³⁵ 'TACO' was an acronym for 'Trump Always Chickens Out'.³⁵ The term satirized the Trump administration's tendency to announce tariff policies that caused pain to the market and economy, only to quickly retract them when faced with a negative reaction.³⁵ On Wall Street, an investment strategy of buying stocks when they plunged after a tariff announcement and then selling for a profit when the policy was paused or withdrawn and the market rebounded began to be called the "TACO trade".³⁵

The term went viral after a reporter directly asked President Trump about it at a White House press conference. President Trump expressed his displeasure, calling it a "nasty question" ³⁶, but this reaction only served as a catalyst for the 'TACO' meme to spread through social media.³⁵ AI-generated images of President Trump in a chicken costume holding tacos became popular online ³⁵, and the Democratic National Committee even staged a political performance by sending a taco truck depicting Trump as a chicken to the Republican National Committee headquarters to distribute free tacos.³⁵

The emergence of the 'TACO' phenomenon was a symbolic event showing that after the April market crash, the public's reaction had moved beyond simple fear and anxiety to a stage where they viewed the administration's policies as predictable "bluffing" and made it a target of ridicule.

Table 3: Key Metrics Matrix for the April 2025 Market Crash and Rebound Period

Date	S&P 500 Close (Change)	VIX Index Close	Consumer Confidence Index	Key Event
Apr 2	Sharp decline begins	Sharp rise begins (records 45.31)	-	'Liberation Day' reciprocal tariffs announced
Apr 3	-4.84%	-	-	Nasdaq experiences worst sell-off

				since 2020
Apr 4	-5.97% (-10% in two days)	Nears peak	-	China imposes 34% retaliatory tariff
Apr 7	Hits lowest point of the year	-	-	Market crash deepens, 3-day loss is worst since Black Monday
Apr 9	Sharp rise (V-shaped rebound begins)	Sharp decline begins	-	Administration announces 90-day tariff pause
Apr 29	Recovers significantly from low	Stabilizing trend	86.0 (13-year low)	Conference Board April Consumer Confidence Index released
May 13	Turns positive for the year	-	-	S&P 500 recovers to year-start level on news of trade negotiation progress
Note: Index data represents market conditions on the respective dates, and exact figures may vary				

slightly by source. ²⁵				
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Section 5: The New Equilibrium: Navigating Uncertainty (June – October 2025)

5.1 Political Strategy: Negotiation and Industrial Policy

After the market crash in April, the administration's strategy shifted from unilateral shock therapy to a parallel approach of negotiation. Between April and August, tentative agreements to lower tariffs were reached with major allies such as the UK, EU, Japan, and South Korea.¹⁰ After the 90-day pause ended, country-specific tariffs with rates somewhat moderated from the original announcement, reflecting these negotiation outcomes, were officially implemented in early August.²

Simultaneously, the administration deepened its direct intervention in the economy through American-style industrial policy. The government used its "golden share" in U.S. Steel to prevent a factory closure and acquired stakes in Intel and the rare earth producer MP Materials.¹ Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent justified these actions as essential to counter "non-market economies" like China, declaring that the government would actively foster and protect 5 to 7 key industries, including pharmaceuticals, semiconductors, and shipbuilding.⁴⁴ This marked a significant shift away from the free-market principles that form the bedrock of American capitalism toward a mercantilist model where the state directs the course of specific industries.

Meanwhile, the legal justification for the IEEPA tariffs was challenged in federal court, which ruled them unlawful, but they remained in effect pending a final Supreme Court decision scheduled for November 2025.²

5.2 Institutional Adaptation

The market continued its V-shaped rebound, adapting to the new reality. The S&P 500 rose

more than 12% year-to-date, remaining near all-time highs through the fall.²⁹ Institutional investors began to price in the new environment where the average effective tariff rate had risen from around 2.5% in 2024 to between 11% and 18%.² A tax cut bill passed in July and strong second-quarter corporate earnings served as positive factors offsetting concerns about increased costs from tariffs.²⁹ Goldman Sachs analyzed that the market was accepting a "New Tariff Reality" as some trade negotiations were concluded.⁴⁶ This meant that the market began to treat high levels of political risk and trade barriers as the "new normal" and started focusing on companies that could generate profits within it (e.g., AI, defense industry).⁶

5.3 The Fed's Policy Shift

Despite the market's recovery, real economic indicators showed signs of a slowdown. In particular, job growth nearly stalled in September.⁴⁸ In response to this downside risk to the economy, the Fed judged the underlying growth slowdown to be more serious than the temporary inflation from tariffs and cut the benchmark interest rate by 0.25% in September.²⁹

However, this measure did not ease the tension between the administration and the central bank. President Trump continued to criticize Fed Chair Powell, pressing for more aggressive rate cuts.²⁹ The persistent political pressure on the Fed's independence remained another form of uncertainty for institutional investors.

5.4 The Public's Continued Pessimism

The most striking feature of the second half of 2025 was the extreme decoupling between financial market performance and the public's economic perception. While the S&P 500 headed toward all-time highs, public economic sentiment remained at its worst. In an October poll, 74% of the American public said the economy was in poor or fair condition, and a majority opposed the tariff policy.⁴⁸ The percentage of Americans who believed they had a good chance of improving their standard of living fell to 25%, the lowest since the survey began in 1987.⁴⁸ In a Guardian/Harris poll, 53% of respondents believed the economy was worsening, and 60% said their cost of living had increased since the beginning of the year.⁴⁷

This pessimism was attributed to direct price increases from tariffs⁴⁹, a slowing labor market, and overall economic uncertainty.⁴⁸ The rise in the S&P 500 was driven by tax cuts benefiting capital owners and a rally in specific tech stocks, whereas the majority of the public

experienced reality through the real economy of wages, prices, and job security. This "two-track economy," where Wall Street and Main Street moved in different directions, was more than just a statistical discrepancy; it was a significant warning sign that the market's rally was built on a fragile foundation.

Section 6: Conclusion and Future Outlook

6.1 The Four-Actor Interaction Model

The dynamics of 2025 can be summarized by a complex interaction model among the four actors. The **Political Actor** (the administration) played the role of repeatedly applying policy shocks for ideological goals. These shocks were amplified by the **General Public** (collapse of consumer confidence) and **Institutional Actors** (stock market panic selling). The key control mechanism in this process was the ability of institutional actors to induce a policy reversal from the political actor through the threat of a financial system collapse. The April tariff pause was a prime example of this mechanism at work. Meanwhile, the **Fed** played a reactive role, managing the macroeconomic fallout of these clashes. In other words, an unstable cycle of 'Politics provokes → Market reacts → Politics adjusts → Fed cleans up' characterized the market in 2025.

Table 4: Four-Actor Reaction Matrix to Major Events in 2025

Major Event	Politics (Admin/Congress)	Institutions (Corps/Wall St)	The Fed	The Public (Consumers/Investors)
Feb IEEPA Tariffs	Invokes IEEPA to impose tariffs on security grounds.	Re-evaluates supply chain risks. China retaliates, Canada/Mexico negotiate.	Regional Feds begin analyzing inflation impact.	Inflation expectations rise, consumer sentiment begins to fall.
Apr 'Liberation	Declares trade deficit a	Panic selling, market crash.	Stagflation risk deepens.	Consumer confidence

Day' Tariffs	national emergency, announces sweeping reciprocal tariffs.	M&A freezes. Strongly demands policy pause.	Expectations for rate cuts form.	collapses. Investor sentiment in extreme fear.
Apr Tariff Pause	Succumbs to market pressure, pauses tariffs for 90 days for countries other than China.	Explosive relief rally. Leads V-shaped rebound.	-	Short-term sentiment recovers. 'TACO' ridicule emerges.
Sep Rate Cut	Continues to criticize Fed's independence and press for further rate cuts.	Market reacts positively, expects further cuts.	Implements a preemptive rate cut due to concerns about a slowing economy.	Limited direct impact. Economic pessimism persists.

6.2 Long-Term Structural Changes

The events of 2025 left three significant long-term structural changes in the U.S. economy and the world trade order.

1. **The Weaponization of IEEPA:** The justification of using national emergency powers for broad trade policy has established unpredictable political risk as a permanent feature of global commerce.
2. **The Rise of American-Style Industrial Policy:** The government's intervention in key industries through "golden shares" or direct equity investments suggests a shift away from free-market orthodoxy toward a state-led competition model.
3. **The Decoupling of the Market and Public Sentiment:** The widening gap between financial market performance and the public's economic experience has become a potential risk factor that could cause political and social instability in the long run.

6.3 2026 Outlook

Heading into 2026, the market faces several key variables. First, the Supreme Court's ruling on the legality of the IEEPA tariffs will be a major turning point that could determine the market's direction. Second, the continuation of the U.S.-China trade conflict over strategic materials like rare earths is a key geopolitical risk.⁴⁴ Third, the key will be how effectively the Fed can manage monetary policy amid the conflicting signals of inflationary pressure from tariffs and an economic slowdown. The core question for investors is whether the fragile "new equilibrium" formed in 2025 can be maintained, or whether another policy shock will trigger a new cycle of instability.

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